

# Aakriti Saraswat

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## EDUCATION

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### Fordham University

*Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (ABD)*

Dissertation Title: Essays in Development Economics

Committee: Subha Mani (Chair), Sophie Mitra, Andrew Simons

New York, NY

*Expected May 2027*

### Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics

*M.Sc. in Agribusiness Economics*

Pune, India

*2016 – 2018*

### University of Delhi

*B.A. (Honors) in Economics*

Delhi, India

*2013–2016*

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

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**Primary:** Development Economics, Gender, Applied Microeconomics

**Secondary:** Public Economics, Health, Applied Econometrics

## WORKING PAPERS & PROJECTS

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### **Job Market Paper:** *Paving the Path to Safety: Rural Roads and Intimate Partner Violence in India*

- Programs to enhance rural connectivity are often driven by the goal of promoting economic growth and improving access to markets and services. However, the potential social externalities, particularly those operating within households, remain underexplored. Using a regression discontinuity design, I show that access to rural roads reduces intimate partner violence against women. I find improved rural connectivity leads to a significant decline in the likelihood of both sexual and physical violence against women in connected villages by 6 and 5.9 percentage points, respectively. I find rural roads improve women's mobility, educational attainment, financial autonomy, and intra-household agency, which strengthens women's bargaining power within the household. At the same time, improved connectivity enhances men's economic status by shifting towards more skilled occupations, increasing educational attainment and reducing sole-decision making. In this way, roads affect both genders through distinct but mutually reinforcing pathways, jointly contributing to a more equitable and less violent household environment. These findings do not provide support to a male backlash and are consistent with a transition toward a more cooperative household equilibrium.

### *Does Performance-Based Funding Improve Training Outcomes? Evidence from India's STRIVE Program*

- Evaluates the effects of performance-based funding on vocational training capacity, inclusion, and employment outcomes in India using two-stage least squares and a fuzzy regression discontinuity design.

### *Experimenter Demand Effects and Gender Attitudes in India*

- Analyzes how experimenter demand influences reported gender attitudes in India using a randomized survey experiment across five domains of gender roles and behavior.

### *Credit Flows and Agricultural Investment Decisions*

- Examines how access to agricultural credit and the adoption of high-yielding varieties affect investment in agricultural mechanization in India using VDSA panel data and a two-way fixed-effects design.

## PUBLICATIONS

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Sundaram, R., Sharma, V., & **Saraswat, A.** (2020). Anthropometric Measurements for Children in Nuclear and Joint Families. *The Indian Journal of Economics*, 100(399).

## RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

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- World Bank** India  
*Short Term Consultant* 2024
- Evaluated the Skills Strengthening for Industrial Value Enhancement (STRIVE) program conducted by India's Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship.
- National Council of Applied Economic Research** India  
*Research Intern under Dr. Sonalde Desai* 2022
- Cleaned and analyzed data from the India Human Development Survey-II (2011–2012).
- Indian Institute of Management Bangalore** India  
*Research Assistant to Dr. Vidhya Soundararajan* 2019 – 2021
- Analyzed India's manufacturing sector using Annual Survey of Industries data from 2009 to 2015.
  - Conducted literature reviews, cleaned and analyzed data, supported field visits, and prepared research summaries for multiple projects.
  - Helped organize a workshop on panel-data econometrics led by Dr. Jaya Krishnakumar, Professor at the University of Geneva.

## CONFERENCES, PRESENTATIONS & WORKSHOPS

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- CSWEP “Successfully Navigating Your Economics PhD” Mentoring Workshop** (November 2026)
- Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (SEA)** (November 2026)
- North American Meetings of the Regional Science Association International (NARSC)** (November 2026)
- New York State Economics Association Annual Conference (NYSEA)** (October 2026)
- International Conference on Empirical Economics (ICEE PSU Altoona)** (2026)
- Fordham University Three Minute Thesis Competition** (2025)
- Fordham University Economics Department Brown Bag Series** (2025)
- Fordham University Research Day Poster Session** (2024, 2025)
- Fordham University Economics Department Applied Microeconomics Workshop** (2024, 2025, 2026)
- Fordham University Economics Department Research and Writing Poster Session** (2023)

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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- Fordham University** New York, NY  
*Teaching Fellow* 2023 – 2025
- Taught five sections of Principles of Microeconomics.
- Teaching Assistant* 2022
- Led workshops for a Ph.D.-level course in Mathematical Methods in Economics II.
- Tutor* 2021 – 2023
- Tutored undergraduate students in microeconomics, macroeconomics, econometrics, and statistics.
- Johns Hopkins University** Baltimore, MD  
*Instructor* 2023

- Taught two sections of Mathematics of Competitive Behavior (Game Theory).

## Indian Institute of Management Bangalore

*Academic Associate*

India  
2019 – 2021

- Conducted Managerial Economics tutorials for three sections of MBA students.

## University of Delhi

*Instructor*

India  
2018 – 2019

- Taught six sections of Introductory Microeconomics and Macroeconomics.

## FELLOWSHIPS, HONORS & AWARDS

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Alumni Dissertation Fellowship, Fordham University (2026–2027)  
 Research Fellowship, Fordham University (2025–2026)  
 Jesuit Pedagogy Seminar Award, Fordham University (2025)  
 Donna Smolens Summer Research Fellowship, Fordham University (2024)  
 Teaching Fellowship, Fordham University (2023–2025)  
 Student Support Grant, Fordham University (2023, 2024, 2025)  
 GSAS Graduate Teaching Assistantship, Fordham University (2022–2023)  
 GSAS Graduate Centennial Scholarship, Fordham University (2021–2022)

## PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & DEVELOPMENT

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Mentee, Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (2025–2026)  
 Participant, Jesuit Pedagogy Seminar, Fordham University (2025)  
 Member, Econometrics Reading Group, Department of Economics, Fordham University (2024–Present)  
 Trainee, Preparing Future Faculty Intensive Program, Fordham University (2024–2025)  
 Economics Representative, Graduate Student Council, Fordham University (2023–2024)  
 Volunteer, SHEWings Foundation (2018–2019)

## SKILLS

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**Statistical Software and Programming:** Stata, R, Python, L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X, and Microsoft Office  
**Languages:** Hindi (native) and English (fluent)

## REFERENCES

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### Dr. Subha Mani

Professor of Economics  
 Department of Economics  
 Fordham University  
 smani@fordham.edu

### Dr. Andrew Simons

Associate Professor of Economics  
 Department of Economics  
 Fordham University  
 asimons5@fordham.edu

### Dr. Sophie Mitra

Professor of Economics  
 Department of Economics  
 Fordham University  
 mitra@fordham.edu

### Dr. Johanna Francis

Associate Professor of Economics  
 Department of Economics  
 Fordham University  
 ajofrancis@fordham.edu